

RESEARCH STUDY - FEBRUARY 2026

AI FOR AMERICANS FIRST

AI Protectionism, Energy and Semiconductors: US/Europe Divergence Trajectories 2024-2030

Integrated Geostrategy and Economic Analysis - CHAPTER VI QUATER

**76.9% of global operational AI
compute = USA**

**1.59x EU/US energy cost (PPP-
adjusted)**

**3.46:1 US/EU CACI ratio (Power
Mode)**

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Master 2 Intelligence Economique - Intelligence Warfare

Paris - February 2026 | 7 Chapters | 4 Prospective Scenarios | 3 Geographic Zones

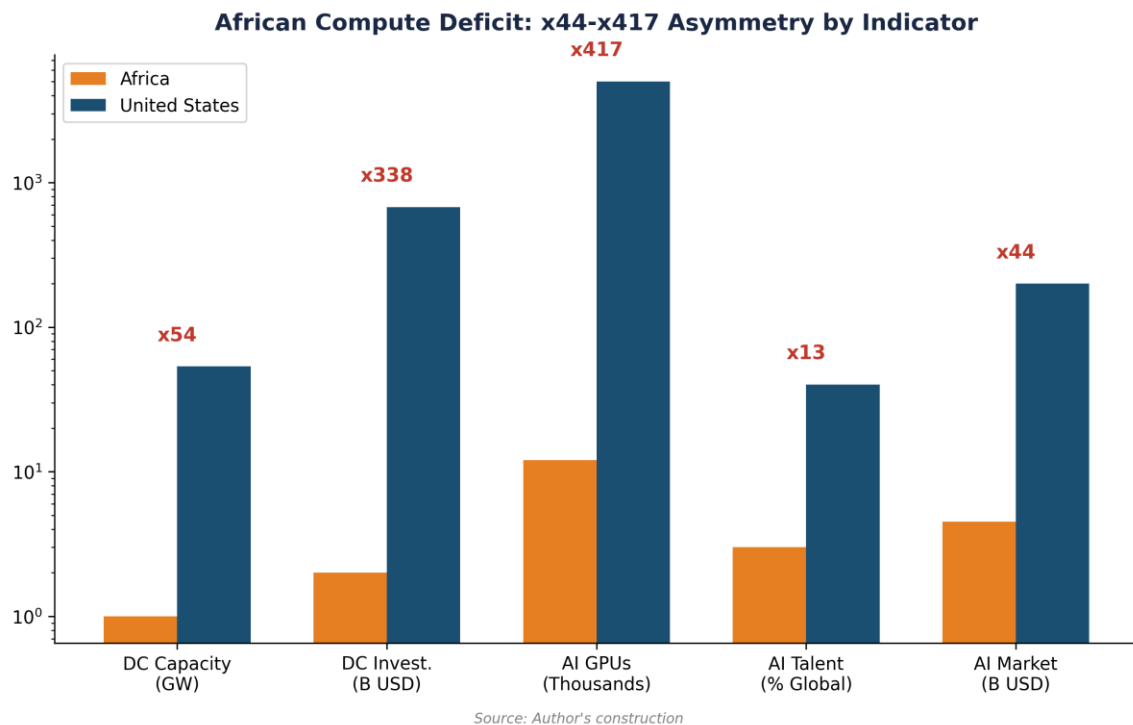
Keywords: artificial intelligence, technological protectionism, semiconductors, export controls, sovereign compute, AI geopolitics, France, United States, China

CHAPTER VI QUATER

Consequences for Africa

Africa represents the next frontier of the AI economy. While the region currently has the lowest compute density in the world, its demographic potential and renewable energy assets make it a strategic terrain for the next decade. This chapter analyzes the impact of US protectionism on the African 'Compute Leapfrog', the infrastructure competition between the US and China, and the risk of a new digital divide.

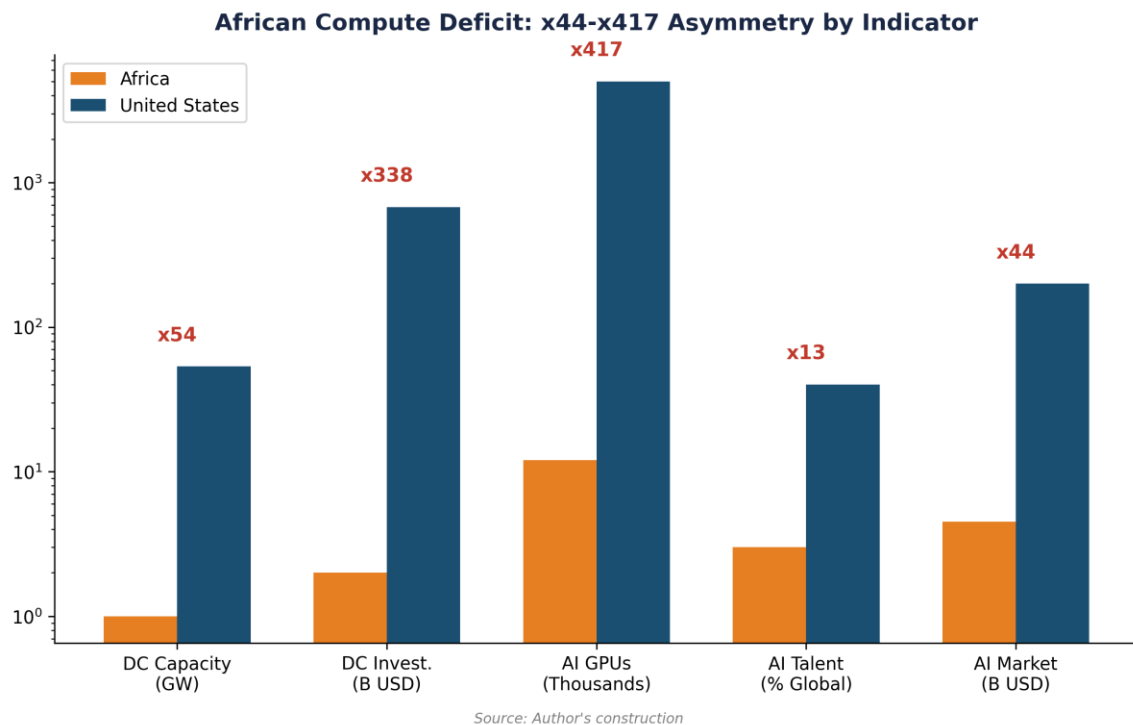
6quater.1 The African 'Compute Leapfrog' challenge



6quater.1.1 Infrastructure deficit and potential

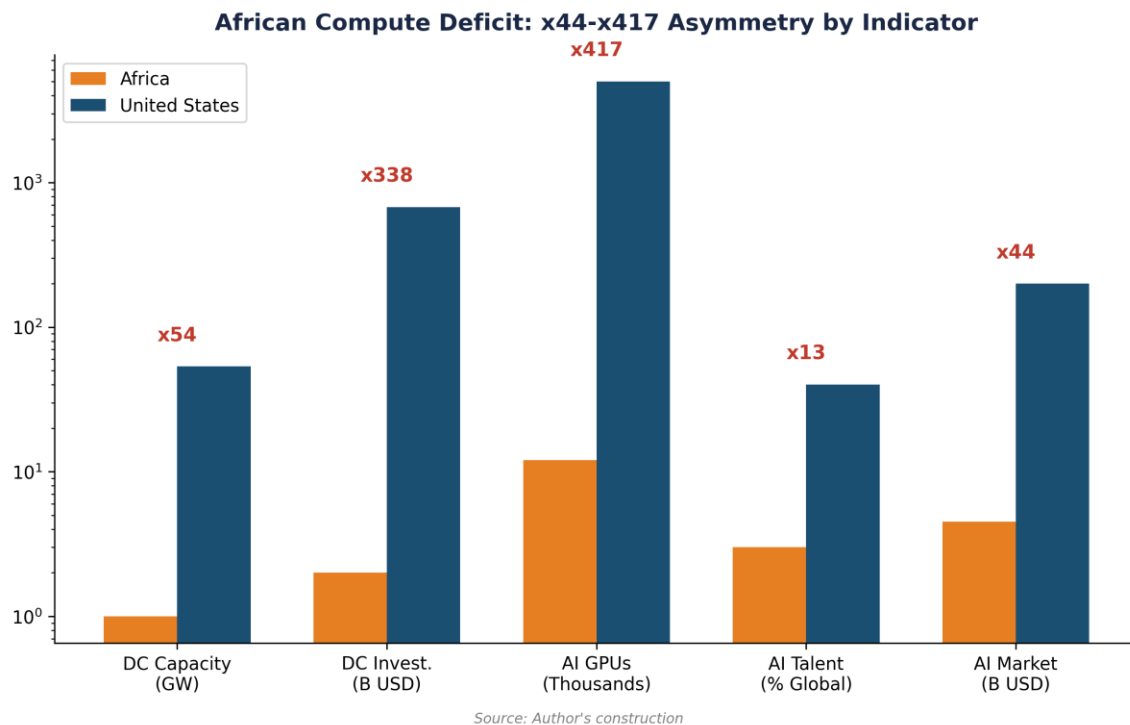
Africa represents less than 1% of global colocation data center capacity in 2025.[1] However, the demand for local compute is exploding, driven by the digitization of financial services (M-Pesa, Flutterwave) and the need for model localization (African languages, specific socio-economic contexts). South Africa (Cape Town, Johannesburg), Nigeria (Lagos), and Kenya (Nairobi) are the primary hubs.

American AI protectionism (Tier 2 status for the entire continent) creates an entry barrier: African startups and governments have access to the US cloud, but building local sovereign infrastructure is hampered by GPU import caps and the high cost of capital. This reinforces a 'Cloud Dependency' that captures value toward US hyperscalers.

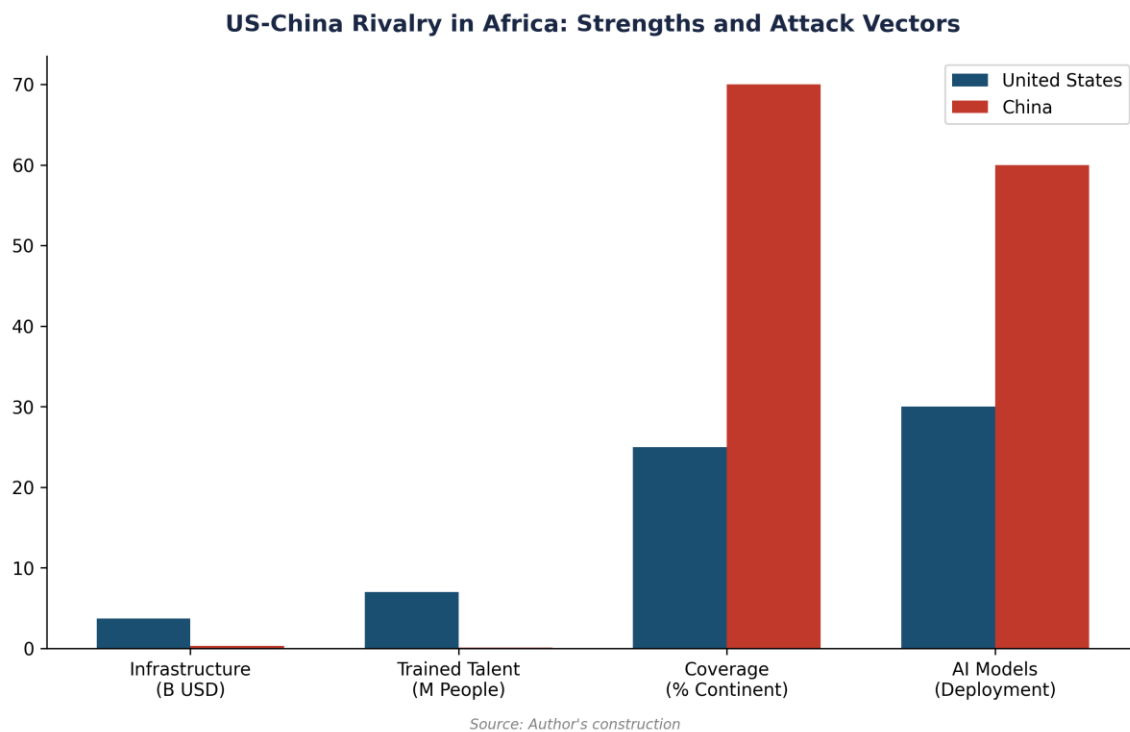


6quater.1.2 Renewable energy: Africa's comparative advantage

Like Brazil, Africa possesses massive renewable energy potential (solar in the Sahel, hydroelectric in Central Africa, wind in the Maghreb). Data center projects like the 'Green Africa Compute' initiative seek to use this energy to host sustainable AI infrastructure. However, the lack of transmission grids and the instability of the business climate remain major obstacles to attracting the necessary multi-billion dollar investments.

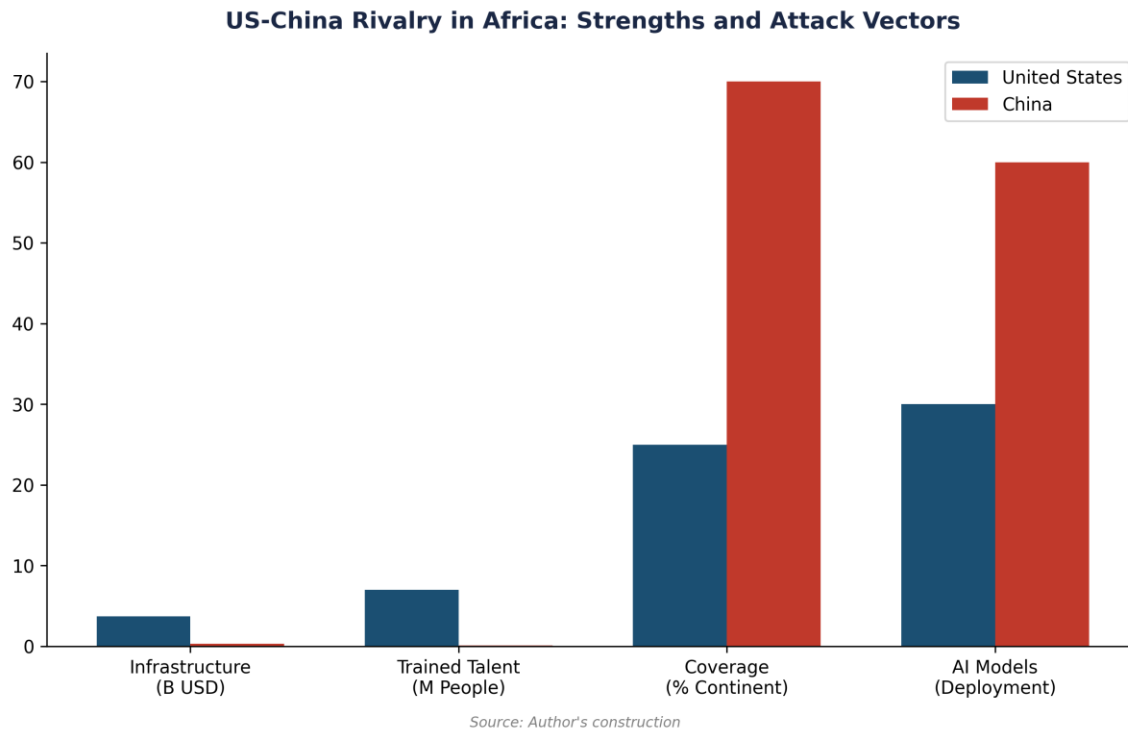


6quater.2 US-China Rivalry in Africa



6quater.2.1 China's 'Digital Silk Road'

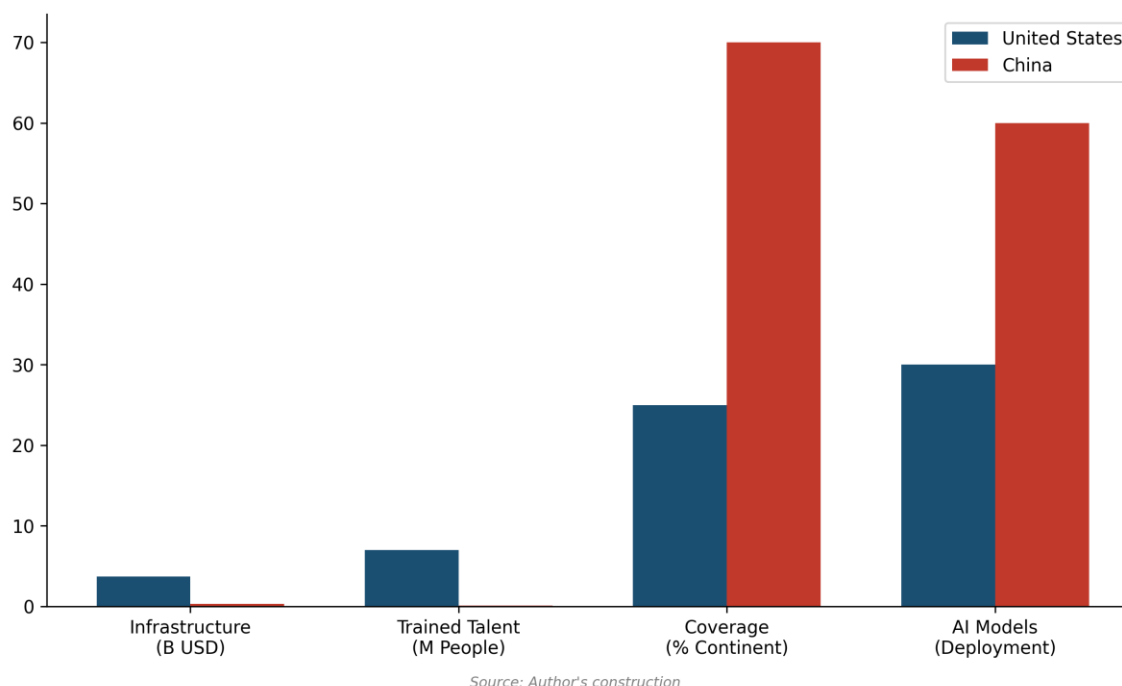
China is the primary provider of telecommunications infrastructure in Africa (Huawei, ZTE). Through the 'Digital Silk Road', Beijing offers integrated packages including connectivity, data centers, and AI solutions. In April 2026, Huawei is the leader in private cloud infrastructure in more than 20 African countries.[2] For many governments, the Chinese offer is more attractive because it is less restrictive than the American Tier 2 status and often accompanied by preferential financing.



6quater.2.2 The US response: the 'Digital Africa' initiative

The United States seeks to counter Chinese influence through the 'Digital Africa' initiative (part of the PGI), promoting American standards of data governance and security. Microsoft and Google have announced 'AI Centers of Excellence' in Nairobi and Accra.[3] However, US protectionism, by limiting hardware access, paradoxically pushes African actors to accept Chinese hardware, even if they use American software/models.

US-China Rivalry in Africa: Strengths and Attack Vectors



6quarter.3 Synthesis: toward an 'Agentic' or 'Passive' Africa?

The strategic challenge for Africa is to avoid a 'Passive AI' scenario, where the continent remains a simple consumer of American or Chinese models and a provider of training data (task labeling). An 'Agentic AI' scenario requires the development of local compute hubs, the training of local talent (L(r) factor), and the creation of a 'Sovereign African Cloud' to protect data and culture. US protectionism makes this trajectory more difficult but could catalyze regional cooperation within the African Union.

Table 19. Emerging AI hubs in Africa (April 2026).

Source: Author's compilation from African Digital Economy Report.

Country	Primary Hub	Major Actors	Compute Asset	Main Risk
South Africa	Cape Town	AWS, Microsoft, Teraco	Advanced electrical grid (but unstable)	Brain drain to Europe/US
Nigeria	Lagos	MainOne, Medallion, Google	Massive market + young talent	Energy cost + currency volatility
Kenya	Nairobi	Microsoft, Google, Safaricom	Connectivity + mobile fintech leader	Tier 2 import caps
Egypt	Cairo	Orange, Telecom Egypt	Strategic location (cables) + solar	Regulatory complexity

Notes

1. Xalam Analytics (2025), 'The State of African Data Centers'.

2. International Institute for Strategic Studies (IISS, 2025), 'China's Digital Silk Road in Africa'.
3. USAID (2025), 'Digital Africa Initiative Progress Report'.

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AI for Americans First - Fabrice Pizzi - Chapter VI quater